Estimated Primary Energy Consumption in the United States, Selected Years, 1635–1945

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Quadrillion Btu

	Fossil Fuels				Renewable energy				
						Biomass			
	Coal	Natural gas	Petroleum	Total	Conventional hydroelectric power	Wood [a]	Total	Electricity net imports [b]	Total
1635	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	(s)	(s)	– –	(s)
1645	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.001	0.001	– –	0.001
1655	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.002	0.002	– –	0.002
1665	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.005	0.005	– –	0.005
1675	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.007	0.007	– –	0.007
1685	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.009	0.009	– –	0.009
1695	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.014	0.014	– –	0.014
1705	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.022	0.022	– –	0.022
1715	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.037	0.037	– –	0.037
1725	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.056	0.056	– –	0.056
1735	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.08	0.08	– –	0.08
1745	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.112	0.112	– –	0.112
1755	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.155	0.155	– –	0.155
1765	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.2	0.2	– –	0.2
1775	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.249	0.249	– –	0.249
1785	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.31	0.31	– –	0.31
1795	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.402	0.402	– –	0.402
1805	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.537	0.537	– –	0.537
1815	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.714	0.714	– –	0.714
1825	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	0.96	0.96	– –	0.96
1835	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	1.305	1.305	– –	1.305
1845	NA	– –	– –	NA	– –	1.757	1.757	– –	1.757
1850	0.219	– –	– –	0.219	– –	2.138	2.138	– –	2.357
1855	0.421	– –	– –	0.421	– –	2.389	2.389	– –	2.81
1860	0.518	– –	0.003	0.521	– –	2.641	2.641	– –	3.162
1865	0.632	– –	0.01	0.642	– –	2.767	2.767	– –	3.409
1870	1.048	– –	0.011	1.059	– –	2.893	2.893	– –	3.952
1875	1.44	– –	0.011	1.451	– –	2.872	2.872	– –	4.323
1880	2.054	– –	0.096	2.15	– –	2.851	2.851	– –	5.001
1885	2.84	0.082	0.04	2.962	– –	2.683	2.683	– –	5.645
1890	4.062	0.257	0.156	4.475	0.001	2.515	2.516	– –	6.991
1895	4.95	0.147	0.168	5.265	0.003	2.306	2.309	– –	7.574
1900	6.841	0.252	0.229	7.322	0.01	2.015	2.025	– –	9.347
1905	10.001	0.372	0.61	10.983	0.017	1.843	1.86	– –	12.843
1910	12.714	0.54	1.007	14.261	0.029	1.765	1.794	– –	16.055
1915	13.294	0.673	1.418	15.385	0.045	1.688	1.733	0.002	17.12
1920	15.504	0.813	2.676	18.993	0.064	1.61	1.674	0.003	20.67
1925	14.706	1.191	4.28	20.177	0.087	1.533	1.62	0.004	21.801
1930	13.639	1.932	5.897	21.468	0.122	1.455	1.577	0.005	23.05

1935	10.634	1.919	5.675	18.228	0.146	1.397	1.543	0.005	19.776
1940	12.535	2.665	7.76	22.96	0.171	1.358	1.529	0.007	24.496
1945	15.972	3.871	10.11	29.953	0.289	a1.261	1.55	0.009	31.512

[a] There is a discontinuity in the "Wood" time series between 1945 (in this table) and 1949 (in *Monthly Energy Review* Table 10.1). Through 1945, data are for fuelwood only; beginning in 1949, data are for wood and wood-derived fuels.
[b] Electricity transmitted across U.S. borders. Net imports equal imports minus exports.
NA=Not available. – – =Not applicable. (s)=Less than 0.5 trillion Btu.

Notes: • For years not shown, data are not available. • See *Monthly Energy Review* Tables 1.3 and 10.1 for continuation of these data series beginning in 1949. • See Note, "Geographic Coverage of Statistics for 1635–1945," at end of section.
Sources: • Fossil Fuels: Energy in the American Economy, 1850–1975, Table VII. • Conventional Hydroelectric Power: Energy in the American Economy, 1850–1975, Table I. Data are converted to Btu by multiplying by 3,412 Btu per kilowatthour. • Wood: 1635–1845—U.S. Department of Agriculture, Circular No. 641, Fuel Wood Used in the United States 1630–1930, February 1942. This source estimates fuelwood consumption in cords per decade, which were converted to Btu using the conversion factor of 20 million Btu per cord. The annual average value for each decade was assigned to the fifth year of the decade on the assumption that annual use was likely to increase during any given decade and the average annual value was more likely to reflect mid-decade yearly consumption than use at either the beginning or end of the decade. Values thus begin in 1635 and are plotted at 10-year intervals. 1850–1945—Energy in the American Economy, 1850–1975, Table VII. • Electricity Net Imports: Energy in the American Economy, 1850–1975, Tables I and VI. Electricity net imports are assumed to equal hydroelectric consumption minus hydroelectric production (data are converted to Btu by multiplying by 3,412 Btu per kilowatthour).

Note. Geographic Coverage of Statistics for 1635–1945.

This table presents estimates of U.S. energy consumption by energy source for a period that begins a century and a half before the original 13 colonies formed a political union and continues through the decades when the United States was still expanding territorially. So, what exactly do we mean by "U.S. consumption" of an energy source for those years when the United States did not formally exist or consisted of less territory than now?

We carefully reviewed the documents used to assemble the estimates, and (as far as possible) the sources of those documents, for clues to geographic coverage. For most energy sources, coverage expanded more rapidly than the nation, defined as all official states and the District of Columbia. Estimates or measurements of consumption of each energy source generally appear to follow settlement patterns. Populations made energy sources in areas of the continent settled enough to have economically significant consumption even though those areas were not to become states for years. The wood data series, for example, begins in 1635 and includes 12 of the original colonies (except Georgia) as well as Maine, Vermont, and the area that would become the District of Columbia. By the time the series reaches 1810, the rest of the Lower 48 continental states are all included, although the last of these did not achieve statehood until 1912. Likewise, the coal data series begins in 1850 but includes consumption in areas, such as Utah and Washington (state) that were significant coal-producing regions but had not yet attained statehood. However, no data were available on state-level historical coal consumption. The coal data in this table through 1945 describe *apparent* consumption, that is production plus imports minus exports. The geographic coverage for coal was based on a tally of coal-*producing* states listed in various historical issues of *Minerals Yearbook*. Coal was likely to have been consumed in states where it was not mined in significant quantities.

By energy source, the extent of coverage summary includes:

- Coal—35 coal-producing states by 1885
- Natural Gas—All Lower 48 states, the District of Columbia, and Alaska by 1885
- Petroleum—All Lower 48 states, the District of Columbia, and Alaska by 1885
- Conventional Hydroelectric Power—Coverage for 1890 and 1895 is uncertain, but probably the Lower 48 states and the District of Columbia; coverage for 1900–1945 was the Lower 48 states and the District of Columbia
- Wood—All Lower 48 states and the District of Columbia by 1810